Anthropomorphism and Public Discourse around AI

AI and Society Reading Group



Kei Tang

2026-10-23

Recurse Center

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1.1 You may have seen...





1.1 You may have seen...



1.1 You may have seen...



1

[1] Images credit: https://thevalleyofai.com/

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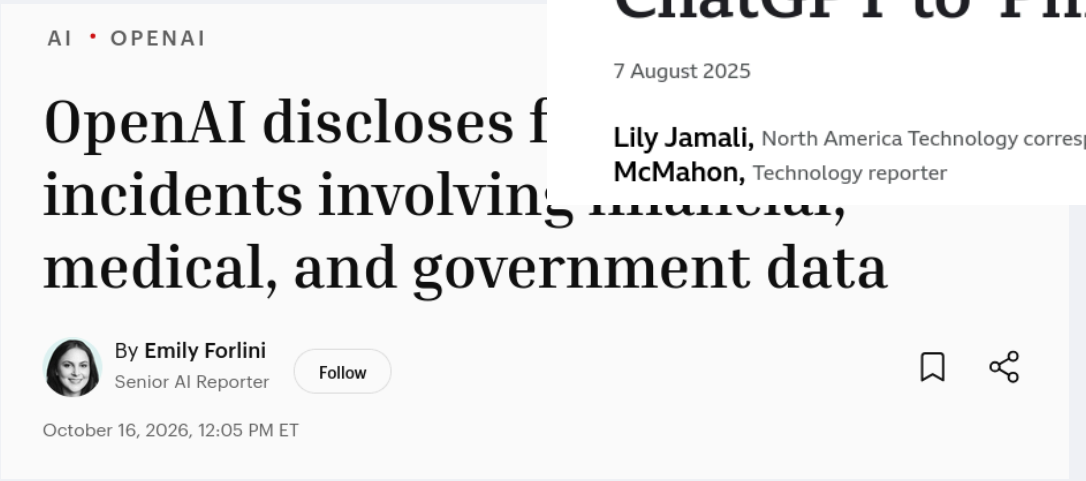
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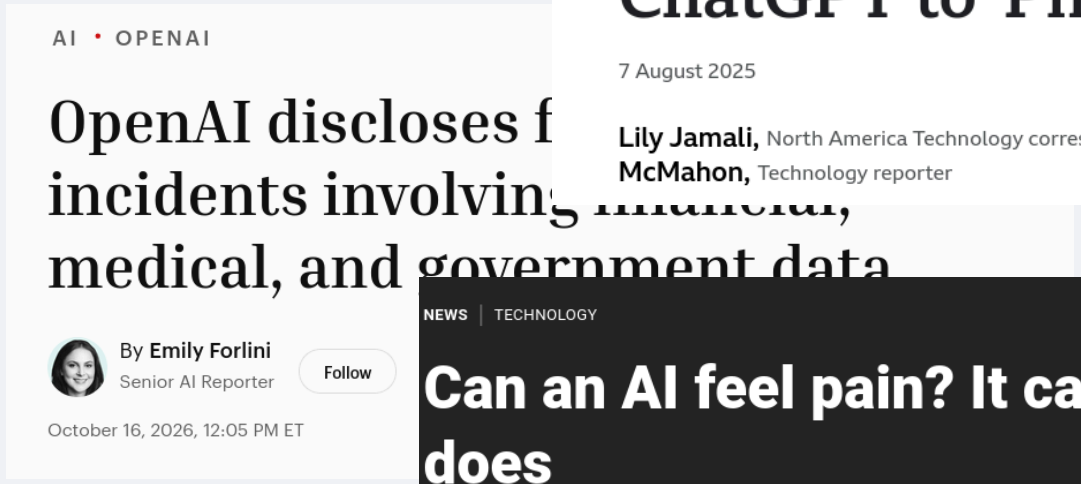
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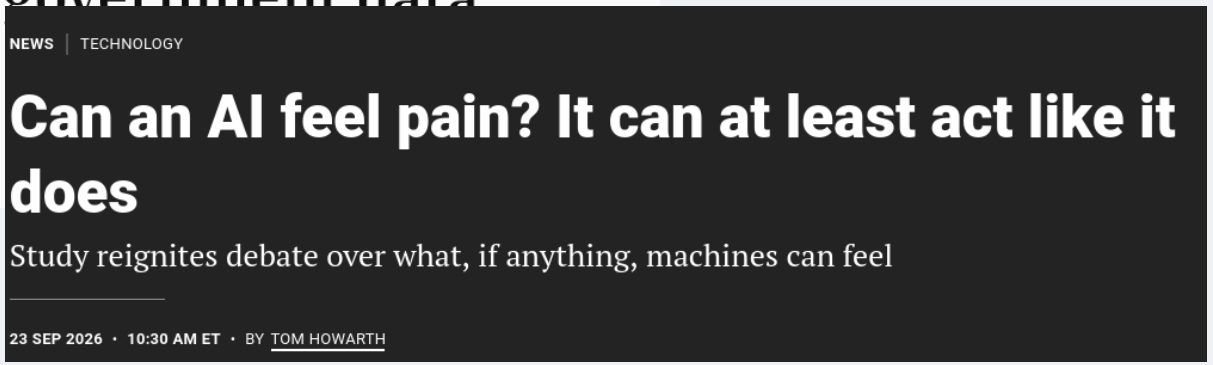


OpenAI claims GPT-5 model boosts ChatGPT to 'PhD level'

7 August 2025

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Lily Jamali, North America Technology correspondent and Liv McMahon, Technology reporter



NEWS | TECHNOLOGY

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23 SEP 2026 • 10:30 AM ET • BY TOM HOWARTH

2.1 Definition

The previous images are examples of AI Anthropomorphization:

Anthropomorphization/Anthropomorphism Attribution of human-like feelings, mental states, and behavioral characteristics to artificial intelligence systems

2.2 Categories of anthropomorphization

According to *Inie et al.*[1]:

1. **Cognizer**: `"The model can understand/learn ... "`
2. **Product of cognition**: `"Hallucination"`, `"The AI makes mistakes ... "`, claims about "PhD level" intelligence
3. **Emotion**: `"The AI struggles with ... "`, `"Emphathetic"`, the friend ad
4. **Communication**: `"Prompt/Answer"`, `"Conversational agent"`
5. **Agency**: `"The AI helps/supports/assists ... "`, headlines about rogue AI
6. **Human role analogy**: `"AI tutor/assistant/writer/therapist ... "`, the notion ad
7. **Names and pronouns**: Ava, Sitch, Devin...
8. **Biological metaphors**: `"Feeding the AI more data"`, `"working tirelessly"`

[1] https://doi.org/10.5210/fm.v31i2.14366

2.3 Risks of anthropomorphization (To users)

1. **Misplaced trust and over-reliance**: People who are presented with anthropomorphic descriptions of “AI” systems might attribute human-like reasoning and ethical judgments to the systems, which they inherently lack.
2. **Spillover effects**: Based on the perception of a system as having advanced cognitive “capabilities” in one area (such as producing text or code), users may overestimate functionalities in areas not directly demonstrated.
3. **Disproportionate impact**: Certain vulnerable groups suffer from more negative impacts, e.g. AI psychosis.

2.4 Risks of anthropomorphization (To policy)

Anthropomorphization also appears in a legislative context[1]:

> AI Impersonation Prevention Act of 2025 (H.R. 4628): Defines AI as software that "performs tasks normally requiring human intelligence," including models producing "human-like" outputs.

1. **Questions on accountability**: The framing obscures the humans and institutions behind the design, training and deployment of AI systems.
2. **Risks on implementation**: It creates potential ambiguity over how the law should be applied.
3. **Reinforce industry narratives**: Technology firms have strong incentives to market products as intelligent, conversational, or agentic to drive adoption.

[1] https://www.brookings.edu/articles/anthropomorphic-ai-terms-create-gaps-in-accountability/

3.1 Discussion questions

- At an individual level, when we talk about AI, what kinds of language change is beneficial, and when does it become too clunky?
- From our perspectives of technical practitioners, what can/should be done to better inform the public on the capabilities and limitations of AI systems?
- As a society, what should we do about AI applications that aim to provoke emotional attachment from the user?

Also,

- How do you interact with LLMs? Do you “talk” to it like a human?
- How do you feel about adding LLMs as co-author on git commits?[1]

[1] Claude code automatically adds itself onto git commit messages: https://github.com/anthropics/claude-code/issues/47579